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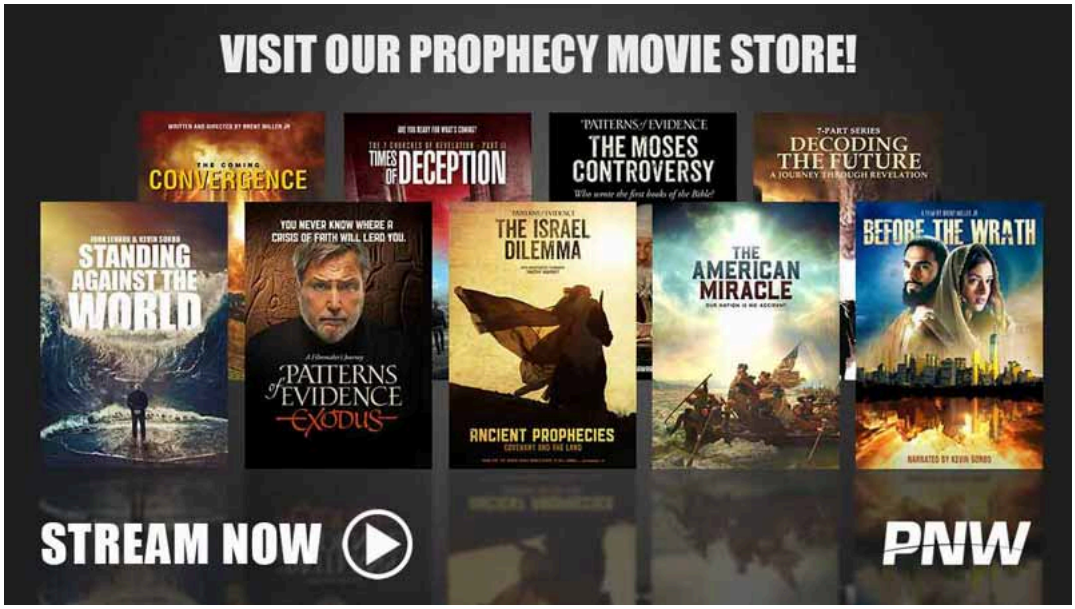

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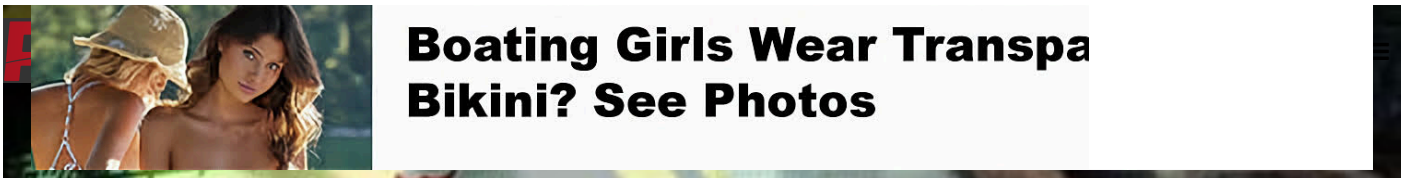
America On Alert: Iran's Sleeper Cells And The Rising Lone-Wolf Threat



BY PNW STAFF MARCH 02, 2026

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The death of Ali Khamenei may mark the end of one man's rule--but it could ignite a far more unpredictable and dangerous phase of conflict. Security analysts and intelligence officials are sounding alarms that Tehran's retaliation may not come only through missiles or proxies abroad, but through something far harder to detect and stop: sleeper cells and radicalized lone actors already living in Western societies.

Former Israeli intelligence chief Yossi Kuperwasser, now affiliated with the Jerusalem Institute for Strategy and Security, warned that dormant operatives linked to Tehran exist "around the globe" and could be activated to strike targets tied to U.S. or allied interests. Having led research for the Israel Defense Forces intelligence division, Kuperwasser's assessment is not speculation from the sidelines--it reflects decades of watching how state sponsors of terrorism behave after losing key leaders.

His message is blunt: sleeper networks are designed precisely for moments like this. They wait silently for years, blending into communities, building ordinary lives, and then, when triggered, they act. The activation signal could be direct orders, coded online messages, or instructions relayed through intermediaries already embedded in Western countries. According to Julian Richards of the University of Buckingham, such cells can be "virtually impossible to spot" until they move.

European officials share the concern. German lawmaker Marc Henrichmann told Sueddeutsche Zeitung that Iran has repeatedly demonstrated its willingness to conduct operations beyond its borders and that retaliatory attacks inside Western nations "cannot be ruled out." That is diplomatic language for a deeply unsettling reality: Western intelligence agencies are bracing for impact.

The Border Question No One Wants to Address

If sleeper operatives already exist in the West, how did they get there? Critics argue that years of porous migration controls in parts of Europe and North America have increased vulnerability to infiltration. While most migrants seek safety or opportunity, hostile regimes need only a handful of determined operatives to exploit gaps. Intelligence services have repeatedly warned that adversarial states study immigration systems carefully, looking for bureaucratic blind spots.

The United States, home to millions of immigrants from across the world--including roughly 2.5 million Shiite Muslims--faces a delicate balancing act: maintaining openness while preventing exploitation. The risk is not the community itself; it is the possibility that a tiny fraction could be coerced, recruited, or radicalized. Two Iranian expatriates in London previously described being pressured during visits back to Iran to perform tasks for the regime, sometimes after authorities temporarily confiscated passports. Such tactics illustrate how intelligence recruitment can occur quietly and coercively.

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Lone Wolves: The Hardest Threat to Stop

Even more alarming than sleeper cells are self-radicalized individuals who act without direct orders. Lone-wolf attackers require no network, no funding pipeline, and no logistical chain. All they need is motivation--and geopolitical crises can supply that instantly.

That danger came into sharp focus this week in Austin, Texas, where a gunman opened fire inside a crowded bar, killing two and wounding 14 before police shot him. Investigators say the attacker, identified as a former New York resident originally from Senegal, may have been motivated by U.S. strikes against Iran. Reports indicate he wore a shirt reading "Property of Allah," possessed a Quran in his vehicle, and allegedly kept images of Iranian leaders and symbols at home. Authorities are examining whether ideological sympathy--not operational direction--drove the violence.

That distinction matters. A centrally coordinated plot can sometimes be intercepted through surveillance or informants. A lone sympathizer radicalized online or through propaganda leaves almost no trail until the moment of attack. That is why counterterrorism experts increasingly view decentralized violence as the defining security challenge of this era.

A Strategy of Asymmetric Revenge

Iran's leadership has long relied on asymmetric tactics--leveraging groups such as Hezbollah and the Houthis rather than confronting adversaries head-on. Activating sympathizers abroad fits perfectly within that doctrine. It allows Tehran to retaliate without triggering full-scale war, while still inflicting psychological and political damage.

Iran's foreign ministry has already warned that consequences for Khamenei's death will "extend to the world." That statement should not be dismissed as rhetoric. It is consistent with decades of precedent showing that the regime views global reach as a strategic asset, not a

America on Alert

The FBI has reportedly elevated counterterrorism readiness nationwide, reflecting concern that retaliation could occur on American soil. Such alerts are not issued lightly. They signal credible intelligence indicating heightened risk, even if specifics remain classified.

History shows that moments of geopolitical shock often produce ripple effects far from the battlefield. Assassinations, airstrikes, and regime crises rarely stay contained within national borders. Instead, they reverberate through diaspora communities, ideological networks, and digital spaces where grievances can be amplified and weaponized.

The Real Battlefield Is Psychological

What makes sleeper cells and lone wolves uniquely dangerous is not just their capacity for violence--it is their ability to instill fear. A single attack can alter public perception, polarize societies, and pressure governments into reactive policies. In that sense, the strategic objective is not merely casualties but destabilization.

The West now faces a sobering question: are we prepared for a conflict that may unfold not on distant front lines, but in our own cities, restaurants, and streets?

The answer will depend on vigilance, intelligence cooperation, and a willingness to confront uncomfortable truths about modern security. Because if history has taught us anything, it is this: wars no longer need armies to cross borders. Sometimes, the battlefield is already inside them.

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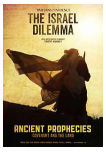

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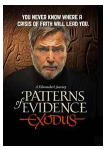

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